

# Buying a Home — Grants & Programs

Think you can't afford to buy? Government-backed loans and down-payment help make homeownership possible with little or even no money down. Below are the main national programs. Tick the box once you've looked into each one.

## ⚠ BEFORE YOU START

There is no single national "free house" grant — real help is a stack of low-down-payment loans, state grants, and tax credits you combine. Legitimate programs never charge a fee just to apply, and a HUD-approved counselor will guide you for free.

## 1 Low- & No-Down-Payment Loans

These federal loan programs let you buy with little or nothing down, with easier credit rules than regular mortgages.

### ☐ FHA Loans

As little as 3.5% down with flexible credit. The most common first-time buyer loan. Offered by approved lenders.

→ [www.hud.gov/buying/loans](http://www.hud.gov/buying/loans)

### ☐ USDA Rural Loans

Zero down payment for homes in eligible rural and many suburban areas. Check the address on the eligibility map.

→ [www.rd.usda.gov/programs-services/single-family-housing-programs](http://www.rd.usda.gov/programs-services/single-family-housing-programs)

### ☐ VA Loans — Veterans & Service Members

Zero down, no ongoing mortgage insurance, for eligible veterans, service members, and some surviving spouses.

→ [www.va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans](http://www.va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans)

## 2 Down Payment & Closing Cost Help

Every state runs a Housing Finance Agency offering grants and forgivable loans — often \$5,000–\$15,000+ — for first-time buyers.

### ☐ Find Your State Housing Finance Agency

Each state offers first-time buyer grants, low-interest loans, and closing-cost help. Find yours here.

→ [www.ncsha.org/housing-help](http://www.ncsha.org/housing-help)

### ☐ HUD — Local Homebuying Programs

HUD's state-by-state list of down-payment assistance and homebuying programs.

→ [www.hud.gov/buying/local-buying-programs](http://www.hud.gov/buying/local-buying-programs)

### 3 Special Buyer Programs

Discounts and programs for specific workers and first-time buyers.

#### ☐ Good Neighbor Next Door

Teachers, law enforcement, firefighters, and EMTs can buy eligible HUD homes at 50% off in revitalization areas (live there 3 years).

→ [www.hud.gov/program\\_offices/housing/sfh/reo/goodn/gnndabot](http://www.hud.gov/program_offices/housing/sfh/reo/goodn/gnndabot)

#### ☐ HUD Homes for Sale

Browse HUD-owned homes for sale, sometimes below market price.

→ [www.hudhomestore.gov](http://www.hudhomestore.gov)

### 4 Get Free Expert Help First

A HUD-approved housing counselor walks you through your budget, credit, and which programs fit — for free.

#### ☐ HUD-Approved Housing Counselor

Free guidance on buying, budgeting, and qualifying for assistance. Find one near you.

→ [www.hud.gov/findacounselor](http://www.hud.gov/findacounselor)

#### ☐ Homebuyer Education Courses

Many grants require a short homebuyer course — your state HFA or a HUD counselor can point you to a free or low-cost one.

→ Ask your HUD counselor or state HFA

#### ⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Skip anyone advertising a guaranteed "\$25,000 buyer grant" for an upfront fee. Real down-payment help comes through your state Housing Finance Agency and approved lenders — and applying is free.

#### ★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Talk to a HUD-approved counselor before you start house-hunting. They'll help you fix your credit, set a budget, and stack the right loan with down-payment help so you keep the most cash in your pocket.

#### NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

#### Ask for your personalized homebuying search

This guide covers the main national programs. For down-payment grants, lenders, and first-time buyer help specific to your state or city, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll help you find them.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID

---

---

---